

Food

Centro Linguistico di Ateneo
Excellence in Linguistic Training



Grammar Focus	Topic Focus
Countable & Uncountable Nouns	British Cuisine
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Countable and Uncountable Nouns

A noun can be *COUNTABLE* or *UNCOUNTABLE*.

Countable

I eat **an apple** every day
I like **apples**

Apple is a **countable** noun. It is something you can **count**.

A **countable** noun can be *singular* (**apple**) or *plural* (**apples**).

We can use numbers with **countable** nouns. So we can say 'one apple', 'two apples', etc.

Examples of nouns that are usually **countable**:
- Sarah was singing **a song**.
- There's **a nice beach** near your house.
- Do you have **a** 5-pound **note**?
- There are no **batteries** in the radio.
- We don't have enough **cups**.

Uncountable

I eat **rice** every day
I like **rice**

Rice is an **uncountable** noun. You **cannot count** it.

An **uncountable** noun has *only one form* (**rice**)

We cannot use numbers with **uncountable** nouns. So we cannot say 'one rice', 'two rices', etc.

Examples of nouns that are usually **uncountable**:
- Sarah was listening to some **music**.
- There's **sand** in your shoes.
- Do you have any **money**?
- There's no **electricity** in the house.
- We don't have enough **coffee**.

Countable and Uncountable Nouns

Countable

You can use **a/an** with *singular countable* nouns

an apple **a beach** **a song**

You *cannot use singular countable nouns alone* (without **a/the/my** etc.):

- I want **an apple** (**not** I want apple)
- You are wearing **a nice coat** (**not** You are wearing nice coat)
- Listen to **this lovely song** (**not** Listen to lovely song)

You can use plural countable nouns alone, when you are speaking **in general**:

- I like **apples** (*apples in general*)
- **Coats** should be worn in winter (*coats in general*)

Uncountable

You cannot normally use **a/an** with *uncountable* nouns.
We do not say 'a rice', 'a sand', 'a music'.
But you can often use **a… of**.
For example: **a packet/a bowl/a grain** of rice

You *can use uncountable nouns alone* (without **the/my/some** etc.):

- I eat **rice** every day.
- Do you have **blood** on your shirt?
- Listen to this lovely **music**!

Countable and Uncountable Nouns

Many nouns can be used as countable and uncountable, with a difference in meaning. Compare:

Countable	*Uncountable*
❖ Did you hear **a noise** just now? (a specific noise)	❖ I can't work here. There's too much **noise** (noise in general)
❖ I bought **a paper** to read (a newspaper)	❖ I have to write a letter. I need **some paper** (material for writing on)
❖ There's **a hair** in my soup! (one single hair)	❖ You've got very long **hair** (not hairs!) (= all the hair on your head)
❖ You can stay with us. We have **a** spare **room** (an extra room in the house)	❖ You can't park here. There isn't enough **room** (the space is too small)
❖ I had **some** interesting **experiences** while travelling (things that happened to me)	❖ They offered me the job because I had a lot of **experience** (not experiences) (= ability, know-how)
❖ Enjoy your trip! Have **a** good **time**! (have fun)	❖ I have to go. I don't have **time**.

Coffee, tea, juice, beer, wine, water (drinks) are normally uncountable

❖ I don't like tea very much

But you can say 'a coffee' (a cup of coffee), 'two coffees' (two cups of coffee), etc.

❖ 'Two beers and a coffee, please!'

Countable and Uncountable Nouns

The following nouns are usually uncountable

Accommodation	Behaviour	Damage	Luck	Permission	Traffic
Advice	Bread	Furniture	Luggage	Progress	Weather
Baggage	Chaos	Information	News	Scenery	Work

You cannot use a/an with these nouns, and the verb must be in the 3rd person singular, because they are **uncountable**, **not plural**:

- I'm going to buy **some bread** or I'm going to buy **a loaf of bread** (*not* a bread or breads!)
- Enjoy your holiday! I hope you have good **weather**! (*not* a good weather)
- Where are you going to put all your **furniture**? (*not* furnitures!)
- Can I give you any more **information**? (*not* informations!)
- The **news** was very depressing (*not* the news were!)

Countable

- She's looking for **a job**.
- What **a** beautiful **view**!
- It's **a** nice **day** today.
- **These chairs** are his.
- We had a lot of **bags**.

Uncountable

- She's looking for **work**. (*not* a work)
- What beautiful **scenery**!
- It's nice **weather** today.
- This **furniture** is his.
- We had a lot of **baggage/luggage**.

Quantifiers

What are quantifiers?
A quantifier is a word or phrase which is used before a noun to indicate the amount or quantity: 'Some', 'many', 'a lot of' and 'a few' are examples of quantifiers.
Quantifiers can be used with both **countable** and **uncountable** nouns.

You can use **some** (in affirmative sentences) and **any** (in questions & negatives) with *plural countable* nouns:
We sang **some songs**.
Did you buy **any apples**?

We use **many** and **few** with *plural countable* nouns:
We have a big house. We have **many rooms**.
She has a **few things** to do.

You can use **some** (in affirmative sentences) and **any** (in questions & negatives) with *uncountable* nouns:
We listened to **some music**.
Did you buy **any apple juice**?

We use **much*** and **little** with *uncountable* nouns:
We have a small house. We don't have **much room**.
She has a **little work** to do.

*Use **much** in negative sentences. For affirmative sentences, use **a lot of**.

We can also use **a lot of**, **lots of** or **plenty of** (*more than enough*) with both *plural countable* nouns and *uncountable* nouns:

We sang **a lot of songs**.
Did you buy **lots of apples**?
We have **plenty of** ideas.

We listened to **a lot of music**.
Did you buy **lots of apple juice**?
We have **plenty of** time.

Quantifiers

Compare:

Few (countable)	***Little (uncountable)***	***A few (countable)***	**A little (uncountable)**
Few *means* ***not many*** ❖ *John is not a very nice person. He has* ***few*** *friends.* (he doesn't have many friends)	***Little*** *means* ***not much*** ❖ Sarah is without a job. She has **little** money to spend. (she doesn't have much money)	***A few*** *means some, a small number* ❖ *Sarah has* ***a few*** *friends that keep her company*	**A little** means some, a small amount ❖ John has a good job and he has **a little** money on the side.

Other examples:

- She **didn't speak much** English, so it was difficult to communicate.
- She spoke **little** English, so it was difficult to communicate.
- She spoke **a little** English, so we were able to communicate with her.

- He's lucky: he has **few** problems.
- He's lucky: he **doesn't have many** problems.

- Things are not going too well: he has **a few** problems.
- Things are not going too well: he has **some** problems.

Past Perfect Simple

The Past Perfect Simple is the past version of the Present Perfect Simple.
We form it this way:
Subject + Past Simple of the auxiliary HAVE = HAD + Past Participle (3rd column of the list for **irregular** verbs or base form + -ED for **regular** verbs) of the verb we need to use. The affirmative and negative can both be contracted.
Since the Past Perfect Simple is a **compound tense**, and it has its own auxiliary, the question will be formed by INVERTING the subject and the auxiliary, and the negative will be formed by adding the NOT, as we did in the Present Perfect Simple. For example:

Affirmative	Contracted Form	Interrogative	Negative	Contracted Form
I had eaten	I'd eaten	Had I eaten?	I had not eaten	I hadn't eaten
You had slept	You'd slept	Had you slept?	You had not slept	You hadn't slept
He had drunk	He'd drunk	Had he drunk?	He had not drunk	He hadn't drunk
She had written	She'd written	Had she written?	She had not written	She hadn't written
It had flown	It'd flown	Had it flown?	It had not flown	It hadn't flown
We had cleaned	We'd cleaned	Had we cleaned?	We had not cleaned	We hadn't cleaned
You had wanted	You'd wanted	Had you wanted?	You had not wanted	You hadn't wanted
They had run	They'd run	Had they run?	They had not run	They hadn't run

When we use the Past Perfect Simple

Let us study this example:
John went to a party last week. Jane went to the party too, but they didn't see each other.
John left the party at 10:30, and *Jane arrived at 11 o'clock*. So:
When Jane arrived at the party, John wasn't there.
He **had gone** home.
Had gone is the Past Perfect Simple.

We use the Past Perfect Simple to talk about something that happened in the past.

Jane arrived at the party (Past Simple). This is the starting point of our story IN THE PAST.
Then, if we want to talk about things that happened **BEFORE** this time, we use the Past Perfect Simple.
When Jane arrived at the party, John had already gone home.

- We arrived home and found that somebody had broken into our flat. (Before we arrived home, somebody had tried to enter into our flat)

- When I got to the airport, I discovered that my flight had already departed. (Before I got to the airport, the plane had already taken off)

Just, Already and Yet

As in the Present Perfect Simple, we often use time words (**just, already and yet**) with the Past Perfect Simple, when we are speaking of an activity **in the past.**

JUST = a short time before in the past
Kate **had** JUST **got** home when I phoned.

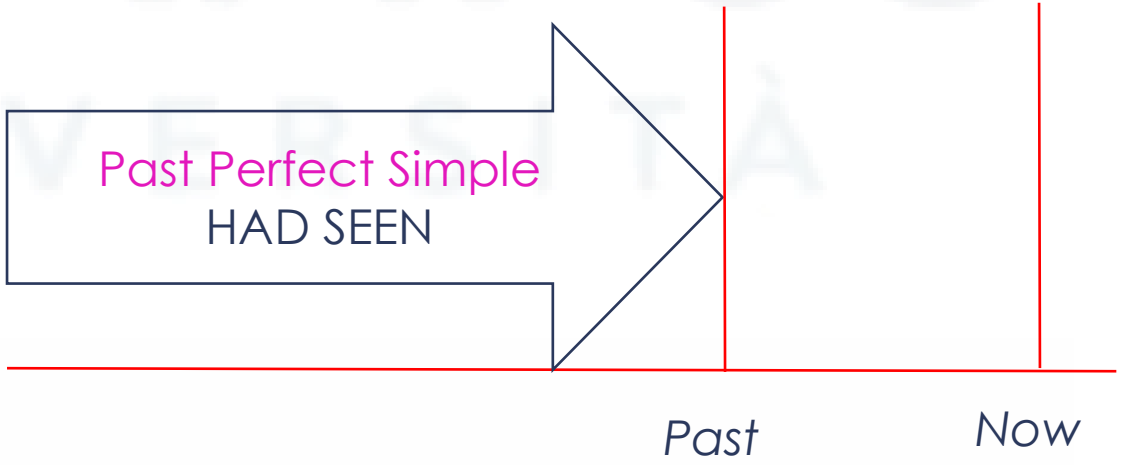
ALREADY = sooner than we had expected
Tom **had** ALREADY **left** when I arrived at the office.

YET = until a moment in the past. It shows the speaker was expecting something to happen.
Use YET only in negative sentences, and put it at the END of the sentence.
'I **had written** the email, but I **hadn't sent** it YET.'

Compare the Present Perfect Simple and the Past Perfect Simple



- Who's that woman? I have seen her before, but I can't remember where.
- We aren't hungry. We have just had lunch.
- The house is dirty. They haven't cleaned it for weeks.



- I wasn't sure who she was. I had seen her before, but I couldn't remember where.
- We weren't hungry. We had just had lunch.
- The house was dirty. They hadn't cleaned it for weeks.

Past Perfect Continuous

How do you form the Past Perfect Continuous?

The Past Perfect Continuous is a mixture between the Past Perfect Simple and the Present Continuous.
Example: I had been eating

We form it in this way: Subject + Past Simple of the auxiliary HAVE (= HAD) + Past Participle of the auxiliary BE (= BEEN) + the infinitive of the verb we want to use + -ING.

Affirmative	Contracted Form	Interrogative	Negative	Contracted Form
I had been eating	I'd been eating	Had I been eating?	I had not been eating	I hadn't been eating
You had been sleeping	You'd been sleeping	Had you been sleeping?	You had not been sleeping	You hadn't been sleeping
He had been drinking	He'd been drinking	Had he been drinking?	He had not been drinking	He hadn't been drinking
She had been writing	She'd been writing	Had she been writing?	She had not been writing	She hadn't been writing
It had been flying	It'd been flying	Had it been flying?	It had not been flying	It hadn't been flying
We had been cleaning	We'd been cleaning	Had we been cleaning?	We had not been cleaning	We hadn't been cleaning
You had been wanting	You'd been wanting	Had you been wanting?	You had not been wanting	You hadn't been wanting
They had been running	They'd been running	Had they been running?	They had not been running	They hadn't been running

When we use the Past Perfect Continuous

Let us study this example:
Yesterday morning I got up and I looked out of the window. The sun was shining, but everything was covered in snow.
It had been snowing.
It **was not snowing** when I looked out of the window, because the sun was shining. But it had been snowing **before I got up.**
Had been –ing is the **Past Perfect Continuous**.

We use the Past Perfect Continuous to say that something *had been happening for a period of time* **before something else happened**, often expressed in the Past Simple or Past Perfect.

I was very tired when I got home. I had been working all day.
When she arrived home, she was soaking wet. It had been raining and she had forgotten her umbrella.

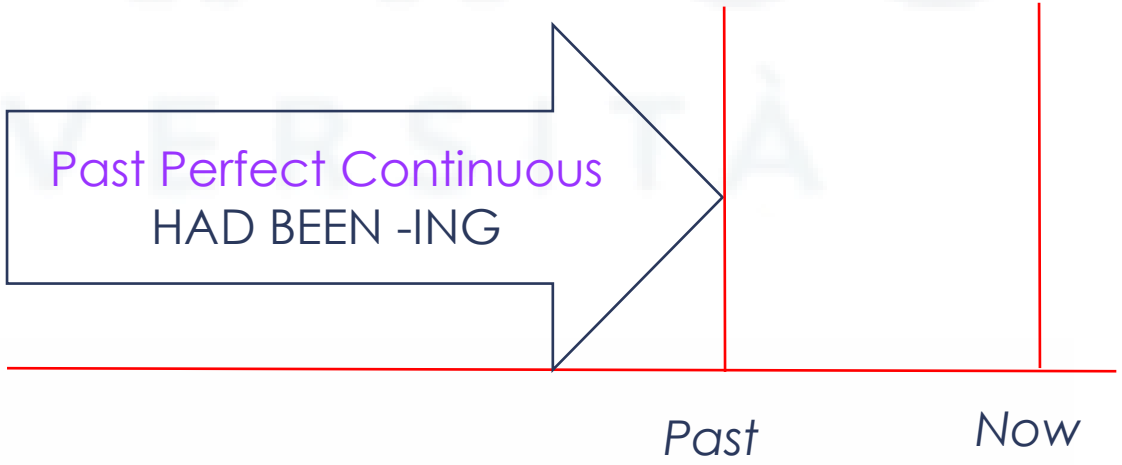
Remember! Some verbs, for example KNOW and LIKE are not used in the Continuous tenses!
You must use the Past Perfect Simple!

Example: We were good friends. We **had known** each other for years. (*not had been knowing*)

Compare the Present Perfect Continuous and the Past Perfect Continuous



- I hope the bus comes soon. We have been waiting for 20 minutes (*before now*)
- John is out of breath. He has been running



- At last the bus came. We had been waiting for 20 minutes (*before the bus came*)
- John was out of breath. He had been running.